

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART NINE OF SIXTEEN

The Gurus and the Mughals

A hundred years in which the community of Part Eight acquires an army — and then does the one thing no power in this entire book has ever managed: it builds something that does not die when its leader does.

1605 — 1708

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EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning



The Century Punjab Learns to Fight for Itself

Every part of this book so far has described somebody else's army fighting on Punjabi ground. This one is different, and it is different in a way that changes the rest of the series.

Part Eight ended in 1604 with a book being installed in a shrine at Amritsar, and with an emperor at Lahore who left the people who put it there alone.

He died in October 1605. Within eight months his successor had executed the man who compiled that book.

What follows is a century of intermittent, escalating conflict between the Mughal state and the Sikh community, running through five Gurus, three emperors and a great many other things that had nothing to do with either. **It ends in 1708 with the Punjab possessing something it has not had since the Shahis in Part Five: an army raised from its own population, fighting for its own reasons.**

Four things to hold on to

- **This is not the only war in the part, and this book is not going to pretend it is.** The Mughal empire in these years also lost armies in Central Asia and Afghanistan, failed three times at Kandahar, fought a savage war of succession, and was humiliated repeatedly on the north-west frontier — **all of it staged through the Punjab and paid for out of Punjabi revenue.** Those wars are in here too.
- **The fighting moves into the hills, and stays there.** Part Eight's rule — the hills preserve you and the hills imprison you — becomes the central military fact of this part. Anandpur, Bhangani, Nadaun and Chamkaur are all in the Siwalik foothills, and so is almost everything that matters.
- **The most important thing here is not a battle.** It is what happens at Anandpur in 1699, and then what happens at Chamkaur in 1704 and at Nanded in 1708 — three moments in which authority is deliberately moved out of one man and into an institution. **Nothing in the previous eight parts does this.** Every army in this book so far has dissolved when its commander went down.
- **And for the first time we can hear the other side.** Jahangir wrote about Guru Arjan in his own memoir. Guru Gobind Singh wrote about his own battles, and wrote a letter to Aurangzeb that survives. **This part has both emperors and their opponents describing the same events in the first person, and that has not been true anywhere in this book before.**

HOW THIS PART HANDLES A DIFFICULT SUBJECT

The conflict in these pages is between a Muslim empire and a religious community that was not Muslim, and it is used today, by people on several sides, to argue about things that have nothing to do with the seventeenth century. This book is going to try to be useful rather than comfortable, and that means three commitments.

The rule about sources applies evenly. Jahangir's memoir is a ruler explaining himself and is read as such. The Sikh devotional literature of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries is written to edify and is read as such. Where a claim rests on one and not the other, this part says so.

The empire is not treated as one thing. Akbar left this community alone; Jahangir executed a Guru and later travelled with the next one; Shah Jahan's officers fought four battles against a Guru and then left him in peace for a decade; Aurangzeb's policy was different again. **Four emperors, four different postures.** A story that flattens them into a single hostile block is not describing this century.

And the labels are used honestly. **CERTAIN**, **LIKELY**, **STORY** — including where a beloved tradition falls into the third category. That is not disrespect. It is the same standard applied to Alexander in Part Two and to Timur in Part Seven.

Lahore, 1606 — The Execution of Guru Arjan

CERTAIN

The emperor wrote down what he had done and why, in his own memoir, and the reasons he gives are the beginning of everything in this part.

WON BY Jahangir — and it produced the exact opposite of what he intended

WHEN May or June 1606, a few months into the new reign.	WHERE Lahore, in custody.
WHO Guru Arjan, fifth Guru, compiler of the Adi Granth, on the orders of the emperor Jahangir.	THE EVIDENCE Jahangir's own <i>Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri</i>; a Jesuit letter written from Lahore the same year; and Sikh tradition.

What Jahangir says

This is one of the very few events in this book where the man who ordered a killing explains it himself, in writing, without being asked. His memoir is unusually frank, and the passage on Guru Arjan is worth reading closely because everything about it is revealing.

He describes a Hindu at Goindwal on the Beas named Arjun, living in the manner of a religious teacher, who had built up a following over three or four generations. **He complains that too many people believed in him — and specifically that Muslims as well as Hindus were among them.** He calls it a shop of falsehood and says he had long intended either to end it or to bring the man into Islam.

Then he gives the immediate occasion. His son **Khusrau** had rebelled and fled towards the Punjab, and on the way had met the Guru, who — Jahangir says — treated him with favour and made a mark on his forehead.

He orders the Guru brought in, his property confiscated, and his execution.

THREE THINGS ABOUT THAT PASSAGE

First, it is a confession, not an accusation by enemies. This is not a hostile chronicler or a later tradition. It is the emperor's own account, and it is why the fact of the execution is labelled **CERTAIN** rather than argued about.

Second, the reasons he gives are mixed, and the mixture is the point. He names the Guru's growing following — including Muslim followers — as a standing grievance he had held for some time. He also names the meeting with the rebel prince as the trigger. **Historians have argued for a century about which mattered more**, and the honest answer is that Jahangir presents both and does not rank them.

Some historians add a third factor: a wealthy community with towns, a central shrine and an income from offerings is a fiscal and political fact as well as a religious one, and new emperors take an interest in such things.

Third, there is independent corroboration. A Jesuit priest at Lahore, **Jerome Xavier**, wrote a letter in 1606 describing the death of a Hindu holy man in the city under the new emperor. **A European clergyman with no stake in the argument, writing from the same city in the same year, is about as good as seventeenth-century evidence gets.**

The detailed traditions about the manner of the death, and about the role of a Lahore official named Chandu Shah, come from later Sikh sources and are not in the contemporary record. This book reports the fact and does not dwell on the details, which are contested and which no purpose is served by rehearsing.

WHY JAHANGIR DID IT

- **A new reign needs to look decisive.** He had been emperor for months, his son had just rebelled, and severity was the standard answer.
- **The rebel connection made it defensible.** Whatever happened between the Guru and Khusrau, it gave the order a political justification rather than a purely religious one.
- **He had inherited a grievance.** His own words say he had wanted to act for some time and had not.
- **And Akbar was dead.** The policy of leaving this community alone was Akbar's personal policy, and personal policies do not survive their author. Part Seven's lesson, in a new setting.

WHY IT WAS A CATASTROPHIC MISCALCULATION

- **It made the succession the point.** The community did not scatter. It installed an eleven-year-old and kept going.
- **It converted a religious movement into a political one.** Before 1606 this community had no reason to arm. Afterwards it had a very specific one.
- **It created a category that did not exist before.** The concept of martyrdom in defence of the faith becomes central to Sikh identity from this moment, and it is the emperor who supplies it.
- **And it did not remove anything.** The book was already compiled and installed. The shrine was built. The organisation was in place. **He killed the man and left the institution standing** — which is exactly the mistake this book has watched empires make since Part Three.

The Instruction Left for a Boy

Sikh tradition records that before his arrest, Guru Arjan sent word to his son about how the succession was to be conducted — and that the instruction was that he should sit fully armed upon the throne, and maintain an army to the best of his ability.

The wording comes from later Sikh sources rather than from any contemporary document, and this book labels it accordingly: **STORY**. Whether those words were said in 1606 cannot be established.

What can be established is that this is precisely what happened.

Guru Hargobind was eleven years old. At his installation he did not take up only the items his predecessors had used. **He put on two swords**, and gave them names — *miri* and *piri*, the temporal and the spiritual — and the meaning was not subtle and was not meant to be. He began keeping horses. He accepted weapons and riders as offerings where his predecessors had accepted money. Within a few years there was a fort at Amritsar and a building facing the Harmandir Sahib from which secular decisions would be taken.

So the tradition may be a later community explaining its own turning point to itself in the form of a dying instruction. Traditions often are. **But the turn is real, it is dated, and its cause is not in dispute: it is a direct response to what happened at Lahore in 1606.**

Jahangir's memoir records the removal of a religious teacher who had attracted too many followers.

What the order actually produced was an eleven-year-old with two swords and a hundred and two more years of this.

The Two Swords — Guru Hargobind Builds an Army, 1606–1620s

LIKELY

A shrine had been built to be walked down into. Facing it, they now built a platform to be sat upon — and the difference between those two buildings is the whole of this part.

WON BY

Nobody — this is a decade of preparation, and one long imprisonment

WHEN

1606 onwards; the imprisonment at Gwalior falls somewhere between about 1609 and 1619.

WHERE

Amritsar, and the fortress of Gwalior.

WHO

Guru Hargobind, sixth Guru, installed at eleven.

THE EVIDENCE

The buildings, later Sikh sources, and the fact that Mughal officers were fighting his men by the 1620s or 1630s.

What was built

1. **The Akal Takht.** Facing the Harmandir Sahib across the tank, a raised platform and building was constructed — the *Akal Takht*, the Throne of the Timeless One. **The architecture is an argument.** The shrine is set below ground level so that you walk down to it, in humility. The Akal Takht is raised, so that authority is exercised from it. Worship in one; decisions in the other.
2. **The two swords.** *Miri* and *piri* — worldly authority and spiritual authority, worn together. The doctrine that the two cannot be separated dates from here, and it is the theological foundation for everything that follows in this part.
3. **A fort.** **Lohgarh** — the iron fort — was built at Amritsar. A religious centre with a fortification is a different kind of place.
4. **Horses and men.** Followers were asked for horses and weapons rather than only for money, and a body of mounted retainers was maintained. The numbers in later sources should be treated with caution; the existence of the force should not.
5. **And the drums.** A war-drum was installed and beaten at the Akal Takht — a public announcement in the most literal available form.

Gwalior

At some point in Jahangir's reign — the dating is genuinely uncertain and the sources disagree by as much as a decade — **Guru Hargobind was imprisoned in the fortress of Gwalior**, which the Mughals used for political detainees.

He was released. Sikh tradition holds that he refused to leave unless the rajas imprisoned with him were freed too, that a condition was set allowing out only those who could hold on to his cloak, and that a garment with many tails was made so that all of them could. **The number given is fifty-two.** The release is commemorated as *Bandi Chhor Divas*, the day of the release of prisoners, and coincides with Diwali.

HANDLE WITH CARE — AND NOTICE WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

The cloak story is **STORY**. It appears in later Sikh sources, not in contemporary record, and the number fifty-two has the shape of a remembered figure rather than a counted one.

The imprisonment itself is accepted; the reason for it is not recorded anywhere reliable. Suggestions range from unpaid fines levied on his father's estate to official unease about the fort and the armed following. Nobody knows.

And here is the part that complicates every simple version of this century. **After the release, the relationship between Jahangir and Guru Hargobind was not hostile.** The sources describe them on reasonable terms, with the Guru accompanying the emperor on travels including to Kashmir. There were no battles in Jahangir's reign after the release.

The same emperor executed the fifth Guru and travelled with the sixth. **Any account of this century that cannot hold both those facts is selling you something.**

WHY THE COMMUNITY COULD ARM AT ALL

- **It had an organisation already.** Part Eight built the districts, the representatives and the system of offerings. Turning offerings into horses is an administrative change, not a revolution.
- **It had a defensible location.** Amritsar was its own town, built by the community, not a quarter of somebody else's city.
- **Its population were farmers.** The Jat peasantry of the doabs joining the community in growing numbers brought with them exactly the horses, the physical hardiness and the tradition of local self-defence that an army needs.
- **And the state was distracted.** Jahangir's reign was consumed by the Deccan, by Kandahar and by his own succession.

WHAT ARMING COST

- **It made the community a military question.** A religious movement can be ignored; a fort cannot.
- **It divided opinion inside the community.** Not everyone thought the two swords followed from Guru Nanak, and rival claimants to the succession made exactly that argument.
- **It put them on a collision course with the local administration,** which is War Three.
- **And it could not match the empire.** A few thousand horsemen against the largest army in the world is not a strategy. It is a way of surviving until the hills.

Two Buildings, Fifty Yards Apart

Stand at Amritsar and look at what was built there in eighty years, because the whole argument of this part is visible in the stonework.

The Harmandir Sahib was completed under Guru Arjan by about 1589. It sits in the middle of a tank, and it is built *below* the level of the surrounding ground, so that a visitor descends to reach it. It has doors on all four sides. Both features are deliberate and both are statements: you come down to it rather than climbing up, and it is open from every direction.

The Akal Takht was built facing it from about 1606, and it is raised. It is a throne — the word is in the name. From it, decisions binding on the community are announced. A war-drum was beaten there.

Fifty yards apart, across water: a building you go down into, and a building you look up at.

That is the doctrine of the two swords rendered in brick, and it was put up within a couple of years of the execution at Lahore. It says that a community which will not defend itself will not survive to worship, and that the people who make the second decision must be the same people who make the first.

Every ruler in the previous eight parts of this book combined temporal and spiritual authority as a matter of course — Ashoka carving moral instruction on pillars, Mahmud collecting titles from the caliph, Akbar making himself the final arbiter in religious disputes. **What is new here is not the combination. It is that the combination is being asserted by people with no state, no throne and no army worth the name, against an empire that had both.**

Within thirty years, Mughal detachments were fighting them. Within a hundred, the Punjab had an army of its own.

The Four Battles of Guru Hargobind, 1628–1635

LIKELY

Four engagements over about seven years, all of them small, all of them won — and then the Guru moved into the hills and the fighting stopped for sixty years.

WON BY Guru Hargobind — in every one, and it changed nothing strategically

WHEN Between about 1628 and 1635. The dates are disputed and some sources place the first as early as 1628 and others as late as 1634.	WHERE Amritsar; Lahira near Mehraj in the Malwa country; Kartarpur in the Jalandhar doab; and Palahi near Phagwara.
WHO Guru Hargobind against local Mughal commanders under Shah Jahan.	THE EVIDENCE Later Sikh sources, chiefly. Contemporary Mughal records say very little, which is itself informative.

What happened

- 1. Amritsar.** The traditional account has the fighting begin over a hunting hawk — a bird belonging to an imperial hunting party seized by the Guru’s men, or the reverse, depending on the version. A force under a commander the sources name as Mukhlis Khan was sent and was beaten.
- 2. Lahira, near Mehraj.** The occasion in the tradition is horses: two fine animals bound for the imperial stables, taken and then recovered by a follower named **Bidhi Chand**, whose exploits are among the best-loved stories in the community. A Mughal force under Lalla Beg was defeated in the Malwa country south of the Sutlej.
- 3. Kartarpur.** Fought against a force that included **Painde Khan** — a Pathan who had been raised in the Guru’s own household and had gone over to the other side. He was killed in the fighting, and the traditional accounts of his death are notably not triumphant.
- 4. Palahi, near Phagwara.** The last of them, fought on the withdrawal.
- 5. And then he left.** Guru Hargobind moved north-east to **Kiratpur**, in the Siwalik foothills, in territory belonging to a hill raja rather than to the empire. There were no further battles in his lifetime, and none for the next sixty years.

WHY THESE BATTLES ARE LABELLED LIKELY AND NOT CERTAIN

Almost everything we know about them comes from Sikh sources written considerably later — the *Gurbilas* literature and the nineteenth-century compilations — which are devotional works composed to inspire. They give the hawk and the horses, the named commanders, the numbers and the heroics.

Contemporary Mughal chronicles barely mention any of it. That silence is not evidence that nothing happened. Court histories record what an emperor's officials wanted recorded, and a local commander beaten by a religious leader's retainers in a Punjab village is not a thing anybody writes to Delhi about with enthusiasm. The Punjab produced dozens of such affrays a decade and almost none of them are in the imperial record.

So the honest position is this. **That armed clashes took place between Guru Hargobind's followers and Mughal detachments in this period is accepted by historians and is consistent with everything else we know** — the fort, the horsemen, the move to the hills afterwards. **The details, the causes and the dates come from a tradition rather than from a record**, and they are held here at arm's length in exactly the way this book has held Kalhana in Part Four and the *Prithviraj Raso* in Part Six.

WHY THE GURU'S MEN WON

- **These were small engagements against local forces.** A provincial commander with a few hundred men, not an imperial army.
- **They fought on their own ground.** Their own town, their own villages, their own countryside, with the population on their side.
- **Motivation is not evenly distributed.** Troops sent to deal with an irritant fight differently from men defending their own place.
- **And they had cavalry.** The Jat peasantry of the doabs supplied horses and riders who did not need training in how to sit on one.

WHY WINNING DID NOT HELP

- **The empire could always send more.** Four victories against local detachments do not change the arithmetic against a state with a million men under arms.
- **Amritsar could not be held.** A town on an open plain, forty miles from Lahore. The oldest lesson in this book.
- **So he went to the hills.** Kiratpur was outside the imperial administration, in a raja's territory, in country that cavalry cannot operate in — which bought sixty years.
- **And the hills imprison as well as preserve.** Part Eight's rule. From Kiratpur you are safe and you are also irrelevant, and everything that happens for the next two generations happens because of that trade.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Was Raised in the House

Of the four battles, the one that the tradition dwells on is Kartarpur, and it is not because of the tactics.

Painde Khan was a Pathan. By the accounts, he had been brought up in Guru Hargobind's own household, trained there, treated as family, and had fought on the Guru's side in earlier engagements. He was, in the versions that survive, an enormous and formidable man of whom the Guru was fond.

He quarrelled, left, and came back at the head of the other side's troops.

The tradition has them meet in the fighting. Painde Khan is killed. And then — this is the part that has kept the story alive for four hundred years — **the Guru is described as shading the dying man's face from the sun with his shield, and speaking to him.**

Take the scene as devotional literature, because that is what it is; nobody was taking notes.

But notice what a community chooses to remember about its own victories, because that is a historical fact even when the scene is not. Of four battles won, the one preserved in most detail is the one where the enemy was somebody they had loved, and the remembered image is not the killing blow but the shield held up against the sun.

This book has spent eight parts reading victory literature — Persian court histories counting the dead, Sanskrit inscriptions cataloguing subdued kings, Timur's memoirs explaining a massacre as administration. **The genre is not usually like this.**

Balkh and Kandahar, 1646–1653 — The Wars the Punjab Paid For

LIKELY

Shah Jahan spent seven years and an enormous fortune trying to take countries beyond the passes, and got none of them. Every rupee and every soldier went through the Punjab.

WON BY The Uzbeks and the Persians — without ever fighting a major battle

WHEN 1646–1647 Balkh and Badakhshan; 1649, 1652 and 1653 the three sieges of Kandahar.	WHERE Beyond the Hindu Kush, and at Kandahar — staged from Lahore and Kabul the whole way.
WHO Shah Jahan, with his sons Murad, Aurangzeb and Dara Shukoh commanding in turn.	THE EVIDENCE The Mughal court histories, which record the expenditure with painful precision.

Why they went

Because the Mughals never stopped thinking of themselves as a Central Asian family in exile. **Babur had lost Samarkand three times and taken India as second best** — Part Seven made the point, and it did not go away. Shah Jahan’s ancestral homeland was Transoxiana, and when Uzbek politics fell into disorder in the 1640s the chance to recover it looked real.

Kandahar was a different matter and a more practical one. It sits on the road between Persia and India and had changed hands between Mughals and Safavids repeatedly. It was lost in 1649 and Shah Jahan wanted it back.

What happened

1. **Balkh and Badakhshan were taken in 1646** with relatively little difficulty, and Aurangzeb was installed at Balkh.
2. **And then it became clear that they could not be held.** The country was hostile, the Uzbeks would not fight a decisive battle and would not stop raiding, and supplying an army across the Hindu Kush from India is a proposition that has defeated everybody who has attempted it.
3. **The withdrawal in 1647 was the disaster.** The army came back over the passes late in the season and was caught by winter in the mountains. The accounts describe men and animals dying in the snow in large

numbers. **Everything gained was abandoned within about two years, and the cost is recorded in the court histories in figures that made contemporaries wince.**

4. **Kandahar was besieged three times** — in 1649 under Aurangzeb, in 1652 under Aurangzeb again, and in 1653 under Dara Shukoh with an even larger army and a siege train.
5. **All three failed.** The fortress was strong, the Persians were competent, and Mughal siege artillery could not reduce it before the supply situation forced a withdrawal.

WHY THIS IS IN A BOOK ABOUT THE PUNJAB

Because of what an army is, logistically, before it is anything else.

Every one of these expeditions was assembled, supplied and paid for through the Punjab. The troops concentrated at Lahore. The grain came from the Punjab doabs. The transport animals were bought here. The revenue that funded seven years of failure was drawn substantially from these districts, because the Punjab was one of the wealthiest and best-assessed provinces the Mughals had — Part Eight's *Ain-i-Akbari* tables show exactly how much.

And when armies came back broken, they came back through here.

This is the cost that never appears in a battle account. A province that stages an empire's wars pays for them in requisitioned grain, in commandeered carts and bullocks, in men taken for the transport train, and in the ordinary inflation that follows a large army sitting in your district for a season.

Nobody wrote it down, because nobody has ever written that down. But when Part Ten describes a Punjab that collapses with startling speed in the eighteenth century, the answer starts here — **with seventy years of an empire spending this province on wars in the Deccan, in Central Asia and at Kandahar, and getting nothing back.**

WHY THE MUGHALS FAILED BEYOND THE PASSES

- **Supply across the Hindu Kush is close to impossible.** Every army in this book that has tried it has been destroyed by geography rather than by an enemy.
- **The Uzbeks refused a decisive battle.** There was nothing to defeat, only country to occupy — the problem the Salt Range people posed to Sher Shah in Part Eight, at national scale.
- **Kandahar was too strong for the artillery of the day,** and sieges have a clock: the food runs out before the walls come down.
- **And they were fighting for sentiment.** Balkh was an ancestral homeland, not a strategic necessity. Wars fought for feelings tend to be expensive.

WHAT IT COST

- **The treasury.** Contemporaries and modern historians agree the sums were enormous and that nothing was gained.
- **The army's reputation.** Three failures at one fortress in five years is noticed by everybody on the frontier, and remembered.
- **The frontier settlement.** The Pashtun tribes drew their own conclusions about Mughal invincibility, and War Six is what came of it.
- **And the succession.** Dara Shukoh's failure at Kandahar in 1653 damaged him badly at court, and Aurangzeb made sure it was remembered.

The Return Over the Passes

The Balkh campaign is barely known outside specialist history and it deserves better, because it is the clearest demonstration in this book of a thing this whole series keeps circling.

In 1646 a Mughal army crossed the Hindu Kush and took Balkh — the ancient Bactria of Part Three, the country the Kushans came from, the province Seleucus signed away in 303 BCE. Aurangzeb, then a prince in his late twenties, was installed as its governor. On paper, the family had recovered its homeland.

He was there for a few months, and what he learned in them shaped a fifty-year reign. The revenue did not cover the garrison. The Uzbeks would not fight and would not leave. The country was not conquered so much as stood upon.

By late 1647 the decision was taken to withdraw, and the withdrawal was made too late in the year.

The army came back over the passes in winter. The court histories, which had every reason to minimise it, describe men and horses lost in the snow and the survivors arriving at Kabul in a condition nobody wanted to record in detail.

Now put it beside the other returns over those passes in this book. **Genghis Khan turned back from India in Part Six partly because of the climate. Timur's grandson lost his cavalry to the Punjab monsoon in Part Seven. A British army retreating from Kabul in 1842 will be destroyed in the same country.**

The mountains between the Punjab and Central Asia have killed more soldiers than any general in these sixteen parts. They funnel every invasion of India down one road, and they destroy every army that tries to go back up it at the wrong time of year. Nobody has ever solved them, and the empires that keep trying keep paying for it out of the province at their foot.

The War of Succession, 1657–1659

— Dara Shukoh’s Last Road

LIKELY

The heir to the Mughal empire lost it in two battles and then spent a year running through the Punjab and Sindh, and the road he took is the road every fugitive in this book takes.

WON BY

Aurangzeb — the last Mughal succession decided cleanly, and the most destructive

WHEN Shah Jahan falls ill in September 1657 ; Dara Shukoh is executed in August 1659 .	WHERE Samugarh and Deorai — and then Lahore, Multan, Bhakkar and the road to the Bolan.
WHO Dara Shukoh , the eldest son and designated heir, against his brother Aurangzeb .	THE EVIDENCE Mughal chronicles, and the account of François Bernier , a French physician who was in India and travelled with Dara’s camp.

What happened

1. **Shah Jahan fell ill in 1657** and the four brothers — Dara, Shuja, Aurangzeb and Murad — went to war before anybody knew whether he would live. He did, and watched the rest of it from confinement.
2. **Samugarh, 1658.** Aurangzeb and Murad destroyed Dara’s army near Agra. Dara fled.
3. **He came to the Punjab.** Lahore was his province and its revenue and troops were his best remaining asset. He held it briefly, raised what he could, and could not hold it — Aurangzeb’s forces came up the Grand Trunk Road.
4. **Then Multan, then Sindh.** Down the same road that every beaten claimant in this book has taken since Humayun in Part Eight: Lahore, Multan, the Indus, and then out.
5. **He tried Gujarat and Rajasthan,** raised another army, and was beaten again at **Deorai** near Ajmer in 1659.
6. **And then he was betrayed.** Fleeing towards Persia through the Bolan country, exhausted and with his family, he was taken in by an Afghan chief named Malik Jiwan whose life he had once saved, and who handed him over.

7. **He was paraded through Delhi on a filthy elephant** — Bernier describes the crowds and their reaction — condemned on a charge of apostasy, and executed in August 1659.

WHO DARA SHUKOH WAS, AND WHY THE PUNJAB REMEMBERS HIM

He was a scholar as much as a prince. He studied Hindu philosophy seriously, associated with Sufis and with the Hindu ascetics of Benares, and **commissioned and worked on a Persian translation of the Upanishads** which he called *Sirr-i-Akbar*, the Greatest Secret. He wrote a book arguing that Hindu and Muslim mystical traditions were describing the same reality, and gave it a title that means *the meeting-place of the two oceans*.

That translation had a strange afterlife. It reached Europe in the eighteenth century by way of a Latin version, and was read by German philosophers who had no other access to the Upanishads at all.

The charge on which he was condemned was apostasy, and the intellectual work was cited against him.

Sikh tradition also records a connection: that when Dara was ill, **Guru Har Rai** — the seventh Guru, at Kiratpur — supplied a rare medicine from his stores. Whether it happened is not documented outside the tradition. What is documented is that Aurangzeb afterwards summoned the Guru to account for himself, and that the Guru sent his elder son **Ram Rai** instead — who altered a line of scripture to make it inoffensive to the emperor, and was disowned by his father for it.

That disinheritance matters more than it looks. It established, at the highest possible cost, that the words in the book were not negotiable to please a ruler — and the rival line it created would trouble the community for a century.

WHY AURANGZEB WON

- **He was the better soldier by a wide margin.** Years of command in the Deccan and at Kandahar against Dara's court career.
- **He made alliances and discarded them.** Murad was used to win Samugarh and imprisoned afterwards.
- **He moved fast and did not stop.** Two years from his father's illness to his brother's execution.
- **And he had a simpler case.** Orthodoxy against a prince who had translated the Upanishads was an argument that wrote itself at court.

WHY DARA LOST

- **He had never commanded successfully.** Kandahar in 1653 was his one great independent command and it failed publicly.
- **He kept the throne and lost the army.** Being at court with his father meant patronage; it did not mean loyal regiments.
- **He fled instead of consolidating.** After Samugarh he had Lahore, a province, a treasury and troops — and left rather than fight for it.
- **And he trusted the wrong man at the end,** which is how nearly every fugitive in this book finishes.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Road That Only Goes One Way

Trace the route of a defeated claimant in this book and it is always, without exception, the same route.

Humayun in 1540 loses at Kannauj, falls back on Lahore, argues with his brothers, and goes down through Multan into Sindh and out. **Dara Shukoh in 1658** loses at Samugarh, falls back on Lahore, cannot hold it, and goes down through Multan into Sindh and out. A hundred and eighteen years apart, the same four place-names in the same order.

And it is older than either of them. **Khusrau Malik, the last Ghaznavid, was cornered at Lahore in Part Six. Daulat Khan Lodi was run down in the Punjab in Part Seven. Sikandar Shah Suri went into the Siwaliks in Part Eight.**

The reason is geography and it is completely mechanical. **If you lose in the Ganges plain, the Punjab is the only direction with a road, a friendly province and a way out of India at the end of it.** So everyone goes there. And the Punjab, which had nothing to do with the quarrel, gets the losing army, the pursuing army, and the requisitions of both.

Only one man in this book ever comes back up that road: Humayun, after fifteen years, and it takes a Persian army to do it.

For everyone else, the road through Lahore and Multan is where their story ends — and the province spends four centuries being the corridor along which other people's defeats are conducted.

The Khapash Pass, 1672 — The Frontier Burns Again

LIKELY

A Mughal army was destroyed in a defile north-west of the Punjab for the second time in a century, and the emperor came to Hasan Abdal and spent a year and a half trying to fix it.

WON BY

The Afridis — and the tribes were never subdued, only paid

WHEN

1672, with the Yusufzai revolt of 1667 before it and Aurangzeb at Hasan Abdal in 1674–1675.

WHERE

The **Khyber** country and the passes — and the imperial headquarters at **Hasan Abdal** in the Punjab.

WHO

The **Afridi** and allied tribes against Mughal armies under Muhammad Amin Khan and others.

THE EVIDENCE

Mughal court histories, which do not enjoy this subject.

What happened

1. **The frontier had been simmering since the 1660s.** The Yusufzai rose in 1667 and were put down with difficulty.
2. **In 1672 the Afridis rose,** under a leader the sources call Akmal Khan, and closed the Khyber.
3. **A large Mughal force under the governor of Kabul went in to clear it** — and was caught in a defile the sources call the Khapash Pass, with the tribes above it.
4. **It was destroyed.** The figures given run to many thousands killed and enormous numbers of prisoners and animals taken. The governor escaped with a fraction of his men.
5. **A second force met a similar fate the following year.**
6. **So the emperor came in person.** In 1674 Aurangzeb moved to **Hasan Abdal**, in the Punjab north-west of Rawalpindi, and stayed about a year and a half directing the campaign.
7. **And what worked was not a battle.** It was roads, forts, garrisons, negotiation and, above all, **subsidies** — payments to tribal leaders to keep the passes open. The frontier was quieted by being bought.

THE SAME PASS, STILL FOREVER

Part Eight described the destruction of Raja Birbal's column in the Karakar Pass in 1586 and said that the same thing happens to every regular army that enters this country. Eighty-six years later, it happened again, to a bigger army, in the same way, for the same reasons.

A column strung out on a mountain track. Tribes on the heights. No way to form, deploy or manoeuvre. Destruction along the whole length of the line.

Akbar's answer after 1586 had been roads, forts and payments. Aurangzeb's answer after 1672 was roads, forts and payments. **The British answer after their own disasters in the same passes would be roads, forts and payments.**

Three empires, three centuries, one conclusion, arrived at independently each time after losing an army to learn it.

And notice where the emperor sat while he worked it out. **Hasan Abdal is in the Punjab.** For a year and a half in the 1670s, the Mughal empire was again being run from this province, for exactly the same reason it had been run from Lahore in the 1580s: because the frontier was on fire and the only way to manage it was to be near it.

WHY THE TRIBES COULD NOT BE BEATEN

- **They chose the ground every time.** A defile removes every advantage a regular army has.
- **There was nothing to capture.** No capital, no army, no treasury — the same problem the Gakkhars posed to Sher Shah and the Khokhars posed to everybody.
- **They only had to close the passes.** The empire had to keep them open, which is far harder.
- **And they could be bought, which is not the same as being beaten.**

WHAT IT COST THE EMPIRE

- **Two armies and several years.** At a moment when the Deccan war was already consuming everything.
- **The emperor's presence.** Eighteen months at Hasan Abdal is eighteen months not spent anywhere else, and the Deccan and the Punjab both drifted while he was there.
- **A permanent subsidy.** The payments to the tribes became a standing charge that no later government has ever managed to stop paying.
- **And it emptied the north.** With the field army committed to the frontier and then to the Deccan, the Punjab's own policing was left to provincial officers — which matters a great deal for everything after 1699.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Where the Emperor Was Standing

In 1674 and 1675, Aurangzeb was at Hasan Abdal in the Punjab, running a frontier war that had already eaten two armies.

He was not a young man; he had been on the throne for sixteen years. He had a rebellion in the north-west, an unfinished war in the Deccan that would eventually consume the last twenty-five years of his life, and an empire that on paper was the richest state on earth and in practice was being spent faster than it could be collected.

And in November 1675, while he was still dealing with the aftermath, **a religious teacher from the Punjab hills was executed at Delhi on his orders.**

That is War Seven, and the point of putting them side by side is this. **From inside the imperial administration, the second event was very much smaller than the first.** The frontier had destroyed armies. The Deccan was a war without end. A Guru in Delhi was a provincial matter, disposed of in a paragraph, if that.

Three hundred and fifty years later, almost nobody outside specialist history has heard of the Khapash Pass. **The execution at Delhi is commemorated by a gurdwara at the site, by another where the body was cremated, and by millions of people every year.**

This book has said it in every part and it is never truer than here: **the winner is whoever gets written about** — but the corollary is that the winner does not get to decide which of his own decisions turns out to have been the important one.

Delhi, 1675 — The Execution of Guru Tegh Bahadur

LIKELY

The ninth Guru was executed in a public square in Delhi, and the reason recorded in the Sikh tradition is one that has almost no parallel anywhere in this book.

WON BY Aurangzeb — and it produced a ten-year-old with a great deal of resolve

WHEN November 1675.	WHERE Chandni Chowk, Delhi. The Guru had come from Anandpur in the Punjab hills.
WHO Guru Tegh Bahadur, ninth Guru, and three companions executed with him.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources, chiefly — including the <i>Bachittar Natak</i>, attributed to his son and written within a generation.

What the Sikh account says

Guru Tegh Bahadur had founded a town in the Siwalik foothills in 1665 on land bought from the raja of the local hill state. He called it **Chak Nanaki**, after his mother; it became **Anandpur**, and it is the centre of everything for the rest of this part.

The account preserved in the tradition is this. A delegation of **Kashmiri Brahmins** came to him at Anandpur, reporting forced conversions under the governor of Kashmir, and asked for help. He undertook their cause — and did so on the specific ground that people are entitled to their own faith, including a faith that was not his own.

He was arrested, taken to Delhi, and after some months given the choice of conversion or death. **Three companions — Bhai Mati Das, Bhai Sati Das and Bhai Dyala — were executed before him.** He was beheaded in Chandni Chowk.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SUPPORTS, STATED CAREFULLY

The execution is not in doubt. Two gurdwaras in Delhi mark the place of the death and the place of the cremation, and the event is fixed in Sikh memory with a precision that leaves no room for invention about whether it happened.

The cause is where the sources thin out. Mughal court chronicles of Aurangzeb's later reign are sparse on the whole subject — he had restricted official history-writing — and what survives says very little.

The nearest thing to a contemporary Sikh statement is the *Bachittar Natak*, a composition attributed to Guru Gobind Singh and written within a generation. It describes his father's death explicitly as a sacrifice made for the sake of others' right to their own religious marks and observances, and says that he gave his head and not his resolve. **That is a near-contemporary source from the closest possible witness, and it is why the Kashmiri Pandit account is accepted by most historians.**

Some historians add political factors — the size of the following at Anandpur, its revenue, official unease about a fortified centre in the hills, the rival claims of the disowned Ram Rai. Those may all have contributed. **They do not displace what the closest source says the reason was.**

What can be said without qualification is the shape of the thing, and the shape is genuinely unusual. **A religious leader of one community was executed after taking up the cause of a different community's right to practise its own faith.** This book has covered five thousand years and it does not have another case quite like it.

WHY THE STATE ACTED

- **Aurangzeb's religious policy had hardened.** The *jizya* was reimposed in 1679; temple demolitions were ordered in several provinces; the direction of travel was clear well before that.
- **A fortified centre with a following is a political fact.** Anandpur was in hill territory outside direct administration, and its growth was noticed.
- **The empire was overstretched and nervous.** A frontier war just finished, a Deccan war beginning, and revolts elsewhere.
- **And a public execution is meant to be seen.** Chandni Chowk is the busiest place in Delhi. That was the point.

WHY IT FAILED AS POLICY

- **The succession held again.** A nine-year-old was installed at Anandpur, exactly as an eleven-year-old had been installed in 1606.
- **It confirmed the argument.** The doctrine of the two swords holds that spiritual life cannot be maintained without the power to defend it. This was the demonstration.
- **It made the cause bigger than the community.** A death on behalf of another religion's freedom is not a sectarian grievance and cannot be dismissed as one.
- **And it produced Guru Gobind Singh,** who was nine years old when his father's head was brought back to the hills.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Argument in the Verse

There is a line of reasoning in the *Bachittar Natak* about this death which is worth setting out plainly, because it is the intellectual foundation of everything in the rest of this part and it is usually skipped over in favour of the drama.

The composition describes Guru Tegh Bahadur as having acted for the sake of people's right to their own religious observances — the sacred thread and the forehead mark, both specifically Hindu practices that had nothing to do with his own community's beliefs. **He is described as breaking his own body rather than his resolve, and giving his head without a sound of complaint.**

Read what that claims. It is not that his own faith was under attack, though it was. It is that **the right of anybody to practise their own religion is worth dying for, including when it is not your religion.**

Now measure that against the previous eight parts of this book.

Ashoka in Part Three renounced conquest and asked his descendants not to make war — the closest earlier parallel, and it is an emperor legislating from a position of total power. Akbar in Part Eight held debates between faiths and abolished the tax on non-Muslims — also an emperor, also from strength, and his policy died with him within months.

This is not that. This is a man with a small following in a hill town, with no army capable of anything, no state, no leverage and no protection, going to Delhi on behalf of people who were not his own and who could do nothing for him.

Whether every detail of the tradition is exact cannot be established. **What is established is that the closest source to the event, written within a generation by the man who had the most reason to know, says that was the reason — and that a community which could have chosen any explanation chose that one and has never chosen another.**

Bhangani, 1688 — The First Battle

LIKELY

The tenth Guru’s first battle was fought at twenty-one against a coalition of Hindu hill rajas, and it was a Muslim holy man from Sadhaura who came to fight on his side.

WON BY

Guru Gobind Rai — and he wrote the account himself

WHEN

September 1688.

WHERE

Bhangani, near Paonta on the Yamuna, in the Sirmur hills.

WHO

Guru Gobind Rai — later **Guru Gobind Singh** — against a coalition of hill rajas under **Fateh Shah of Garhwal**.

THE EVIDENCE

The *Bachittar Natak*, a first-person account attributed to the Guru himself. **Unusually good for this book.**

Why the hill rajas fought him

This is the fact that most retellings of this century get wrong, and it needs saying at the start. **Guru Gobind Singh’s first two decades of fighting were mostly not against the Mughal empire. They were against the Hindu rajas of the Siwalik hill states.**

The reasons were about power, not religion, and they were entirely ordinary. Anandpur and Paonta were growing. The Guru’s following was large, armed and expanding into country the rajas regarded as theirs. He accepted followers from every caste, which was corrosive to the social order the hill states were built on. And his presence disturbed the delicate arrangement by which those rajas paid tribute to the empire and were otherwise left alone.

He had moved to **Paonta**, on the Yamuna, under the protection of the Raja of Sirmur — who was in dispute with his neighbour of Garhwal. That neighbour assembled a coalition.

What happened

1. **A confederacy of hill rajas marched on Paonta**, led by Fateh Shah of Garhwal and joined by others including Bhim Chand of Kahlur, in whose territory Anandpur stood.
2. **Part of the Guru’s force deserted.** A body of Pathan mercenaries in his pay went over to the other side before the battle — the *Bachittar Natak* names them and does not soften it.

3. **And a Muslim holy man came to fight for him.** Pir **Buddhu Shah of Sadhaura** arrived with his sons and his followers and fought on the Guru's side. **Two of his sons were killed.**
4. **The battle was fought at Bhangani** and the coalition was broken.
5. **And the Guru wrote it down.** The *Bachittar Natak* gives a first-person account — who fought, who ran, who died, and the confusion of it — in verse.

WHY THE BACHITTAR NATAK MATTERS SO MUCH TO THIS BOOK

Stop and consider what this document is, against everything that has come before it in these nine parts.

It is a commander's own written account of his own battle, composed within his lifetime, in a language of the region, which survives.

Now count the alternatives this book has had to work with. Alexander's battles reached us through Greeks writing four hundred years later. Tarain was described by a Persian court historian in Delhi. Waihind was counted by al-Utbi for his employer. Timur's campaign comes through a text that may not be his. Mihirakula was written up by a Kashmiri poet six centuries afterwards. **In eight parts, the only comparable first-person military document is the *Baburnama* — and Babur was the invader.**

Here the man writing is defending his own ground, and he is writing in the Punjab about the Punjab.

It is not neutral — it is a devotional and autobiographical composition, in verse, by a religious leader, and its purpose is not the purpose of a modern battle report. **But it names the men who deserted him. It records that mercenaries in his pay changed sides. It does not pretend the fight was easy.** Court histories do not usually do those things.

WHY HE WON

- **He was defending, on ground he knew.** The hill country around Paonta, with the river behind the rajas' approach.
- **His people had a reason to fight.** A coalition of rajas assembling to remove a community is a clarifying event for that community.
- **The coalition was a coalition.** Several rajas, several agendas, no single command — the losing formation this book has now documented seven times.
- **And he had unexpected help.** Pir Buddhu Shah's men arrived when the Pathans left, and the arithmetic changed.

WHY THE RAJAS LOST

- **They were fighting a movement, not a rival.** Beating a raja settles a border; beating a community settles nothing.
- **They underestimated a twenty-one-year-old.** He had been Guru since the age of nine and had spent the intervening years preparing for exactly this.
- **Their own subjects were joining him.** Which is why they attacked, and also why they could not win.
- **And they would try again.** Repeatedly, for sixteen years, with the same result until they got the empire to do it for them.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Pir of Sadhaura

Of everything at Bhangani, the detail that deserves to be better known is who turned up.

Pir Buddhu Shah was a Muslim divine of Sadhaura, a town in the plains below the hills, with a following of his own. He had no obligation to the Guru, no shared religion, and nothing to gain. When the Pathan mercenaries deserted, he came with his sons, his brother and his followers, and fought.

Two of his sons were killed in the battle.

The tradition records that afterwards, when the Guru asked what he might give him, the Pir asked for a comb from the Guru's hair with some hairs still in it, and for his turban. That part is devotional tradition and this book marks it as such.

The rest is not in dispute, and it sits awkwardly across every simplified version of this century that anybody wants to tell.

At the first battle of the tenth Sikh Guru, the enemy was a coalition of Hindu rajas, the deserters were Muslim mercenaries in his own pay, and the ally who came unasked and lost two sons was a Muslim holy man.

Hold on to that when Part Ten and Part Eleven get bloodier, because it stops being obvious. The wars in this book divide along lines of power, land, revenue and fear far more often than along lines of faith — and when they do divide along faith, it is usually because somebody in authority found it useful.

Pir Buddhu Shah's own end is recorded as unhappy: the tradition holds that he was killed some years later on the orders of the local Mughal administration, for having helped the Guru.

Nadaun, 1691 — Fighting on the Rajas’ Side

LIKELY

Three years after the hill rajas tried to destroy him, the Guru fought a Mughal army alongside them — and then they went back to being his enemies.

WON BY

The hill rajas and the Guru together — and the alliance lasted about as long as the battle

WHEN 1691.	WHERE Nadaun, on the Beas in the Kangra hills.
WHO Guru Gobind Rai and Bhim Chand of Kahlur, against a Mughal force under Alif Khan.	THE EVIDENCE The <i>Bachittar Natak</i> again — the Guru’s own account.

What happened

1. **The hill rajas stopped paying tribute.** The Mughal governor of Jammu sent a commander named Alif Khan to collect it.
2. **Bhim Chand of Kahlur asked the Guru for help** — the same Bhim Chand who had marched against him at Bhangani three years earlier.
3. **And the Guru came.** He fought at Nadaun on the Beas alongside the rajas, and the *Bachittar Natak* describes the action, including his own part in it, in detail.
4. **The Mughal force was defeated** and withdrew.
5. **Then the rajas made terms with the empire anyway** and resumed paying, which is what hill states do.
6. **And within a few years they were his enemies again**, and would be for the rest of his life.

THE SHIFTING SIDES, AND WHY THEY SHIFTED

Nadaun is the clearest evidence in this part that the wars of the 1680s and 1690s in these hills were not a religious conflict, and it is worth setting out the ledger.

1688 at Bhangani: Hindu rajas attack the Guru; Muslim mercenaries desert him; a Muslim pir fights for him and loses two sons.

1691 at Nadaun: the Guru fights alongside the same Hindu rajas against a Mughal army.

1700 onwards at Anandpur: the same rajas besiege him, then ask the empire for troops, and Mughal and hill-state forces attack him together.

Three configurations in twelve years, involving the same handful of people.

What actually drove it was land, tribute, precedence and fear — the ordinary business of small states with a large neighbour and an inconvenient new power in the middle of them. Religion is present throughout, it matters to everyone involved, and it is not what determines who is on which side in any given year.

That is not a comfortable finding for anyone's preferred version, which is precisely why it belongs on the page.

WHY THE ALLIES WON

- **Hill country against a plains force**, for the fourth time in this book. Nadaun sits on a river in broken ground.
- **A tribute-collecting expedition is not a war.** Alif Khan came to enforce a payment, not to conquer, and such forces withdraw when the cost rises.
- **The Guru's men were the best troops on the field.** Trained, motivated and by now experienced.

WHY IT ACHIEVED NOTHING

- **The rajas settled immediately afterwards.** They wanted better terms, not independence, and a victory improved their bargaining position.
- **The Guru gained a reputation he could not use.** Being the best soldier in the hills made him more dangerous to his neighbours, not less.
- **And it put him in the imperial record.** A religious leader who beats a Mughal detachment in the field becomes an administrative problem with a name.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Twenty-Two Hill States and Not One Alliance

The Siwalik foothills between the Sutlej and the Ravi held a scatter of small kingdoms — Kahlur, Sirmur, Garhwal, Guler, Nurpur, Mandi, Kangra, Bilaspur and a dozen more. They had existed for centuries, they had their own dynasties, their own hill forts and some of the finest miniature painting produced anywhere in India.

And in this part they do nothing but change sides.

They fight the Guru, then fight beside him, then besiege him, then call in the empire, then break their own guarantees. They pay tribute to Delhi, stop paying, are made to pay again. Not one of them ever combines with the others into anything that could resist either the empire or the community growing in the middle of them.

This is the oldest failure in this entire book and it is now in its ninth appearance. Ten kings on the Ravi in Part One. The Malavas and Kshudrakas in Part Two, who combined and then could not agree on a commander. Nine republics submitting separately to Samudragupta in Part Four. Anandapala's confederacy in Part Five, which dissolved when one elephant bolted. Prithviraj's coalition at Tarain in Part Six. The Punjab powers of Part Seven — Khokhars, Langahs, Afghans — who never once made common cause.

Small states in this region do not federate. They bargain individually with whoever is strongest, and are eaten in sequence.

The hill states were absorbed by Ranjit Singh in Part Thirteen, one at a time, without much difficulty. By then they had been failing to combine for a very long time.

Anandpur, 1699 — The Khalsa

CERTAIN

Not a battle. The most consequential thing in this part, and one of the most consequential in the whole book.

WHAT CHANGED

Punjab acquires an army that is not a dynasty, a clan or a mercenary force

WHEN Vaisakhi, 1699.	WHERE Anandpur, in the Siwalik foothills above the Sutlej.
WHO Guru Gobind Singh and the community summoned to the town.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources, and the observable fact that everything afterwards is different.

What was done

The Guru called the community to Anandpur for the spring festival and, before the assembly, asked for a head.

The account is that he asked for someone willing to give his life, took the man who came forward into a tent, and returned with a bloodied sword. He asked again. Five times in all, five men came forward, and after the fifth he brought all five out alive.

These five were the **Panj Pyare**, the Five Beloved. What they had in common was that they had volunteered. What they did not have in common is the point: **they came from different castes and different parts of India, including from groups that Indian society at the time treated as low.**

He then administered an initiation — *amrit*, prepared with water and sugar and stirred with a double-edged sword, with recitation — and established the order:

- The initiated took the name Singh, and women Kaur.** One name for everybody, replacing the surname that announced your caste. **This is not a symbolic gesture; a shared name in a caste society is a demolition.**
- They kept the five articles of faith** — uncut hair, comb, steel bracelet, prescribed undergarment and a blade — worn by everyone, which makes the member of the order visible and impossible to hide.
- They were bound by a code of conduct** that applied to all equally.

4. **And then the Guru asked the five to initiate him.** He received the rite from the men he had just created, on the same terms as anybody else.

WHAT IS DOCUMENTED AND WHAT IS TRADITION

The founding of the Khalsa in 1699 at Anandpur, the initiation, the names, the articles of faith and the code are established beyond dispute — they are the constitution of a community that has existed continuously since, and its practice is the evidence.

The dramatic details of the day — the tent, the sword, the five calls — come from Sikh sources rather than from any external record, and this book flags that in the same way it has flagged everything else. Nobody outside the community was writing it down.

What can be checked from outside is the effect. **Within a year, Mughal and hill-state forces were treating Anandpur as a military problem of a different order.** Within eleven years, an army raised from this order had taken Sirhind and was administering territory. Within a century it ruled the Punjab.

Something happened at Anandpur in 1699 that turned a religious community into a standing military force. **The mechanism is documented in its own constitution, and the results are visible in everybody else's records.**

WHY IT WORKED, MILITARILY

- **It removed caste from recruitment.** Every other Indian army in this book drew its fighting men from restricted groups. This one could recruit from the entire population, and did — overwhelmingly from the Jat peasantry, but formally from anybody.
- **Initiation is a commitment mechanism.** A man who has taken a rite, changed his name and put on visible articles he cannot remove has burned his boats. Deserting is not possible in the ordinary way.
- **It is voluntary.** Nobody is conscripted, levied or bought. Part Five's Ghaznavids ran on slave-soldiers; Part Seven's sultans on assignments of land revenue. **This runs on people who chose.**
- **And authority was distributed.** The Guru taking initiation from the five he created put the order above the man — which is the whole of War Twelve.

WHAT IT COST

- **Visibility.** The articles of faith make a member identifiable at a glance, which is an asset in a battle and a death sentence in a persecution. Part Ten is about that.
- **It split opinion inside the community.** Not everybody accepted the new order, and the divisions of the eighteenth century begin here.
- **It alarmed everybody outside it.** The hill rajas and the imperial administration both read it correctly as the creation of an army.
- **And the war started within a year.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Took the Oath From His Own Men

Go back through the previous nine parts and look for a founder who subordinated himself to the thing he founded.

Chandragupta built an empire and made it his family's. Ashoka carved his conscience on pillars and it died with him. Every Greek king in Part Three, every sultan in Parts Six and Seven, every Mughal in Part Eight — the state was the man, and the man was the state, and when he died it was fought over by his sons. **Part Eight counted five commanders who were winning a battle and lost it because they personally went down.** That is what happens when authority lives in one body.

At Anandpur in 1699, the Guru created an order, and then **knelt and received initiation into it from five men who had been ordinary members of the community that morning.**

Whatever else it was, that is a deliberate act of constitutional engineering. It says that the order is not his property. It says that its authority does not descend from him but is held collectively. And it establishes that the five, acting together, can bind him.

Five years later at Chamkaur, that provision was used, and it saved his life against his own wishes. Nine years later at Nanded he took it to its conclusion and ended personal Guruship altogether, vesting it in the book compiled in Part Eight.

This book has watched states, dynasties, empires and armies dissolve on the death of one man for three thousand years — the Nandas, Menander's kingdom, Harsha's empire, Yashodharman's alliance, Hemu's army, Jasrat's Punjab. It is the single most reliable failure mode in these sixteen parts.

In 1699, in a hill town on the Sutlej, somebody finally solved it.

The Sieges of Anandpur, 1700–1704

LIKELY

Four years of intermittent siege ended with a guarantee of safe passage, given on oath, and broken within hours.

WON BY The besiegers — by starvation and a promise they did not keep

WHEN Fighting from 1700; the final siege and evacuation in December 1704.	WHERE Anandpur and its ring of small forts in the Siwaliks.
WHO Guru Gobind Singh against the hill rajas and imperial forces under the faujdar of Sirhind.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources; some Mughal administrative record; the Zafarnama, the Guru’s own letter to Aurangzeb.

What happened

1. **The hill rajas attacked first**, from 1700, and were repeatedly beaten in the engagements around Anandpur and Nirmohgarh.
2. **So they asked the empire in**. Unable to remove him themselves, the rajas petitioned for imperial troops, and the governors of Sirhind and Lahore supplied them.
3. **The final siege closed in 1704**. Anandpur was invested by a combined force and cut off from supply. It lasted months.
4. **Conditions inside became desperate**. The accounts describe the food gone and the animals eaten. A number of the Guru’s followers left, and some formally renounced him in writing — a document called a *bedava*.
Remember them; they come back in War Thirteen.
5. **Terms were offered**. The besiegers guaranteed safe passage if the town were evacuated — and, according to the Sikh accounts and to the Guru’s own later letter, **swore to it on the Quran**.
6. **The evacuation began on a December night** in rain, with the community strung out on the road.
7. **And the guarantee was broken almost at once**. The column was attacked on the march.
8. **At the Sarsa river, in flood, the family was separated in the dark**. The Guru and his two elder sons went one way with a small party. His mother and his two younger sons went another. **Nothing after that is recoverable.**

ON THE BROKEN OATH — AND ON THE ONE SOURCE THAT ANSWERS BACK

The breaking of the safe-conduct is central to how these events are remembered, and it is not only a later tradition. **The Guru wrote to Aurangzeb about it himself.**

The *Zafarnama* — a letter in Persian verse, sent about a year later and discussed in full in War Thirteen — accuses the emperor directly of an oath sworn on the Quran and broken, and asks what a man's word is worth if his sacred oath is not.

That is not a chronicler's accusation. It is a letter from the injured party to the person he holds responsible, and it survives.

Whether Aurangzeb personally authorised the guarantee, or whether it was given by commanders in the field who exceeded or ignored their orders, is genuinely disputed and cannot be settled here. Imperial armies in this period were commanded by provincial officers with wide discretion, and the emperor was two thousand kilometres away in the Deccan.

What is not disputed is that a guarantee was given, that the column was attacked on the road, and that the man it was given to wrote to the emperor and said so.

WHY THE BESIEGERS FINALLY SUCCEEDED

- **They stopped fighting and started waiting.** Four years of failed assaults, and then a blockade — the same lesson Akbar learned at Mankot in Part Eight.
- **They combined.** Hill rajas plus imperial troops, for once acting together, which the rajas alone had never managed.
- **A fort needs a field army behind it.** Part Five said this at Nandana in 1014 and it has not stopped being true. There was no relief and there was never going to be.
- **And the promise did the last of it.** A garrison that will not surrender to force may leave on terms — which is exactly why the terms were offered.

WHY HOLDING ANANDPUR WAS IMPOSSIBLE

- **It was a town, not a fortress.** A religious centre with defences, holding a civilian population including families.
- **The hills feed nobody.** Part Eight's rule again — you cannot be finished there and you cannot supply an army there.
- **No allies, anywhere.** The rajas were the besiegers and the empire was behind them.
- **And the community inside was not an army.** It was a population, and populations starve first.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Crossing of the Sarsa

The Sarsa is not a large river. In December, in an ordinary year, it is not much of an obstacle at all.

On the night the evacuation reached it, it was in flood, it was raining, it was dark, and there was a Mughal force behind them on the road.

What happened at that crossing is the hinge of the whole part, and it happened in about an hour, in confusion, with nobody in control of it.

The community was cut into pieces at the water. Some got across, some did not, some drowned. Baggage was lost — including, by the accounts, manuscripts. The Guru crossed with a small party and his two elder sons, **Ajit Singh**, seventeen, and **Jujhar Singh**, fourteen. His mother, **Mata Gujri**, crossed separately with the two younger boys, **Zorawar Singh** and **Fateh Singh**, who were about nine and six.

Neither group knew where the other had gone.

Within a week, everything that happens in Wars Twelve and Thirteen had happened, and by the end of December 1704 **all four of his sons and his mother were dead.**

This book has described a great many disasters. What makes this one different is that it was not a battle and nobody planned it. **A river came up, in the dark, at the worst possible moment, and separated a family that would never be in the same place again.**

Every account of these events — devotional, scholarly, hostile — agrees on this much. And it is the reason the winter of 1704 occupies the place it does in the memory of the Punjab: not because of the tactics, but because of what an ordinary flooded stream did to a group of people who were already walking away from everything they had.

Chamkaur, December 1704

LIKELY

Forty men in a mud house against an army — and the most important thing that happened there was an order the Guru did not want to obey.

WON BY The imperial force — which took the house and lost the person it came for

WHEN December 1704, within days of the Sarsa crossing.	WHERE Chamkaur, on the plain below the hills, near the Sutlej.
WHO Guru Gobind Singh and about forty Sikhs, against a pursuing imperial force.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources, and the <i>Zafarnama</i>, which describes it in the Guru’s own words.

What happened

1. **They took shelter in a mud-walled house** — a *garhi*, a fortified compound of the ordinary Punjabi kind, belonging to a local family. It was not a fortress. It had walls and a gate.
2. **The pursuing force surrounded it.** The numbers in the sources are very large and are the usual sort; what is not in question is that the disproportion was extreme.
3. **The Sikhs went out in small parties to fight.** A few at a time, out of the gate, into the surrounding force. This is what you do when you cannot hold and cannot escape: you make the taking of the place expensive.
4. **Ajit Singh, seventeen, went out and was killed.**
5. **Jujhar Singh, fourteen, asked to go, and went, and was killed.**
6. **And then the surviving Sikhs ordered the Guru to leave.**
7. **He went.** With two or three companions, at night, through the encircling force, and escaped into the country to the west.

THE ORDER — AND WHY IT IS THE MOST IMPORTANT MOMENT IN THIS PART

Read carefully what the accounts describe, because it is easy to skim past as a devotional detail and it is not one.

Five of the surviving Sikhs constituted themselves as the Panj Pyare — the five, acting collectively, in the form established at Anandpur in 1699 — **and issued a command to the Guru to leave the position.**

He did not want to go. The accounts are consistent about that. He went because, under the constitution he had himself created five years earlier, **the five acting together could bind him, and he had accepted initiation from them on those terms.**

Now put that beside the previous nine parts of this book.

Porus's elephants turn and his army is destroyed. Anandapala's elephant bolts and eight centuries of Indian coalition-building dissolve in ten minutes. Muhammad of Ghor is wounded at Tarain and his army runs. Qutlugh Khwaja is hit at Kili and a full invasion goes home. Hemu takes an arrow at Panipat while winning, and loses.

Five commanders, five armies, one failure mode: *authority lived in one man's body and could not survive it.*

At Chamkaur, in a mud house, with his two elder sons dead outside the gate, **the machinery built to solve that problem was operated — and it worked.** The institution overruled the leader, the leader complied, and both the institution and the leader survived the night.

It is the single most consequential thing that happens in these hundred years, and it happens in a farmyard.

WHY THE IMPERIAL FORCE TOOK THE POSITION

- **Numbers, against a mud wall.** There was never any doubt about the outcome of the siege itself.
- **They had the pursuit right.** Catching a scattered party days after the Sarsa was competent soldiering.
- **And there was no relief.** Nobody in the Punjab was coming.

WHY IT WAS NOT THE VICTORY THEY NEEDED

- **They came for one man and did not get him.** Everything else was incidental to that objective, and it failed.
- **They gave the community its founding memory.** Forty against an army, in a mud house, is the kind of thing that gets remembered for three hundred years — and has been.
- **The order survived the battle.** The Khalsa was not at Chamkaur. It was scattered across the Punjab, and it still existed on the morning of the 23rd.
- **And within six years an army raised from it took Sirhind.** Which is Part Ten.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Ghani Khan and Nabi Khan

After Chamkaur the Guru was alone in open country in December, hunted, with an imperial administration searching every road.

The tradition records that he was sheltered near **Machhiwara** — a name you have seen already in this book, because Bairam Khan won a battle there in 1555 that refounded the Mughal empire — and that he was then moved out of the district by two Pathan brothers, **Ghani Khan and Nabi Khan**, horse traders who had known him.

They put him in a litter, dressed as a Muslim holy man, and carried him openly along the roads, telling anyone who asked that they were escorting the *Uch da Pir* — the holy man of Uch. The accounts have them stopped and questioned, and a local man vouching for them under oath.

The details are Sikh tradition and this book labels them so. What is not tradition is the shape of the thing, which is corroborated by everything else about this year.

The Guru survived the winter of 1704 because Punjabi Muslims hid him from a Muslim emperor's officers.

Set it beside the rest of the ledger this part has been keeping. At Bhangani a Muslim pir fought for him and lost two sons, while Muslim mercenaries in his pay deserted. At Nadaun he fought a Mughal army beside Hindu rajas who had tried to kill him three years earlier and would try again. At Anandpur those same Hindu rajas called in the imperial troops. And in the worst week of his life, two Pathan horse dealers carried him out of a search cordon.

Nothing in this century sorts cleanly by religion, and the people who lived through it knew that better than anybody arguing about it now.

Sirhind, Muktsar and the Letter, 1704–1708

LIKELY

Two children died at Sirhind, forty deserters came back and died at a pool in the desert, and the man who had lost everything wrote a letter to the emperor telling him he had lost.

WON BY Nobody — and everything in Part Ten comes out of it

WHEN December 1704 at Sirhind; December 1705 at Khidrana; the letter written about 1705–06.	WHERE Sirhind on the Delhi road; Khidrana — now Muktsar — in the dry Malwa country.
WHO Guru Gobind Singh; the faujdar of Sirhind, Wazir Khan; and forty Sikhs who had left him.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh sources, and the <i>Zafarnama</i> in the Guru’s own hand.

Sirhind

The party separated at the Sarsa — Mata Gujri and the two younger boys — was betrayed by a servant and handed over to the authorities at Sirhind.

Zorawar Singh was about nine. Fateh Singh was about six.

They were held at Sirhind, brought before the faujdar Wazir Khan, and required to convert. They refused. **They were put to death in the last week of December 1704.** Their grandmother died at Sirhind at the same time.

This book is not going to describe it further. The manner of the execution is recorded in the Sikh tradition and is commemorated every December, and nothing is gained by setting it out here beyond what has been said. **Two children were killed by a provincial official because they would not change their religion, and the memory of it is one of the load-bearing facts of Punjabi history.**

WHAT SIRHIND BECAME

It is worth stating plainly what these deaths did, because the consequences run through the next hundred years of this book.

Sirhind stopped being a town and became a name. Six years later, in 1710, an army raised from the Khalsa under Banda Singh Bahadur stormed it and destroyed it. Wazir Khan was killed, and the site was left in ruins so deliberately that it was said to be under a curse. That is Part Ten, and it is the reason Part Ten opens the way it does.

And notice which of these events the empire recorded. Aurangzeb's later reign restricted official history-writing, and the Mughal record of the winter of 1704 is thin to the point of silence. A provincial faujdar disposing of the family of a hill-country religious leader was, administratively, nothing at all.

It is the other side that wrote this one down, and that is possible because of what was built in Part Eight and formalised in 1699. **For the first time in this book, the losing side's account is the one that survives in full.**

Khidrana, December 1705

1. **The forty who had left Anandpur during the siege** — the ones who had signed the *bedava* renouncing him — were shamed at home, according to the tradition, by the women of their villages.
2. **A woman named Mai Bhago** — Mata Bhag Kaur — is remembered as having rallied them and led them back.
3. **They found him at a pool at Khidrana** in the dry country of the Malwa, with an imperial force in pursuit.
4. **They fought there and nearly all of them died**, holding the ground long enough for the pursuit to be broken. Mai Bhago survived, badly wounded.
5. **And the Guru is said to have torn up the document.** The forty are remembered as the ***Chali Mukte*** — the forty liberated — and the place was renamed **Muktsar**, the pool of liberation.

WHY THE STATE COULD NOT FINISH IT

- **It kept killing individuals and missing the institution.** Guru Arjan in 1606, Guru Tegh Bahadur in 1675, four sons and a mother in 1704 — and the Khalsa was still there in 1708.
- **The empire was two thousand kilometres away.** Aurangzeb spent the last twenty-five years of his life in the Deccan, and the Punjab was run by provincial officers with local priorities.
- **Persecution recruits.** Sirhind is the clearest demonstration in this book: the killing of two children produced an army six years later.
- **And the country was with them.** A man hunted through the Punjab in 1704 and 1705 was fed, hidden and moved by ordinary people, including people of the emperor's own religion.

WHAT IT COST

- **Anandpur, and everything in it.** The town, the library, the accumulated work of forty years.
- **Four sons and a mother, inside one month.**
- **The community scattered.** The organisation built over a century was broken up and had to be reassembled from nothing.
- **And a century of what follows.** Part Ten and Part Eleven are the bill.

The Letter

Some time in 1705 or 1706, in the Malwa country, having lost his town, his library, his four sons and his mother inside a single winter, **Guru Gobind Singh wrote a letter to the Emperor Aurangzeb.**

It is in Persian, in verse, and it is called the **Zafarnama** — the Epistle of Victory.

It is not a plea and it is not a lament. It is an indictment, written by a man with nothing left, addressed to the most powerful person in the world, and its argument runs roughly like this.

You swore on your Quran and you broke the oath. He returns to this again and again — not as an insult but as a legal and religious point. A ruler whose sacred oath means nothing has forfeited the thing that makes him a ruler.

Your commanders did not defeat me. He describes Chamkaur: a handful of men, an army against them, and what it cost to take a mud house.

Killing my children changes nothing. One of the most quoted lines in Punjabi memory is his — that what does it matter if four have been extinguished, when the coiled one still remains.

And there was no other way left. The most famous couplet in the letter states the principle plainly: when all other means have been exhausted, it is lawful to take up the sword.

Now consider this document against the nine parts before it. This history has been assembled from Greeks writing four centuries late, Chinese pilgrims describing ruins, Persian court secretaries counting the dead for the men who paid them, victory pillars carved by winners, and a Kashmiri poet writing six hundred years afterwards. In Part Seven a Punjabi finally wrote down what an invasion looked like. In Part Eight it was put in a book.

Here, a Punjabi who has just lost everything writes directly to the emperor who took it, in the emperor's own literary language, and tells him he has lost.

Aurangzeb died in the Deccan in 1707. The Guru died at Nanded in October 1708, stabbed by an assassin, having done two last things: he sent a follower north to the Punjab with authority to act — and he ended personal Guruship for ever, declaring that after him the Guru would be **the book**.

The follower was **Banda Singh Bahadur**, and Part Ten begins with him on the road to Sirhind.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1606	Guru Arjan is executed at Lahore on Jahangir's orders, recorded in the emperor's own memoir: Won by Jahangir — and it produces the opposite of what he intended.
1606 onwards	Guru Hargobind takes up two swords , builds the Akal Takht facing the Harmandir Sahib, raises the fort of Lohgarh and begins keeping horsemen.
c. 1609–1619	The Guru is imprisoned at Gwalior and released — commemorated as Bandi Chhor Divas. Relations with Jahangir afterwards are cordial.
c. 1628–1635	Four battles — Amritsar, Lahira near Mehraj, Kartarpur and Palahi. All won. Then the Guru moves to Kiratpur in the hills and the fighting stops for sixty years. Won by Guru Hargobind.
1646–1647	Balkh and Badakhshan are taken and abandoned; the army is caught by winter recrossing the Hindu Kush. Won by the Uzbeks, without a battle.
1649, 1652, 1653	Three failed sieges of Kandahar , all staged and paid for through the Punjab. Won by Persia.
1657–1659	The war of succession. Dara Shukoh is beaten at Samugarh, loses Lahore, runs through Multan and Sindh, is betrayed in the Bolan country and executed. Won by Aurangzeb.
1665	Guru Tegh Bahadur founds Chak Nanaki — Anandpur — in the Siwalik foothills.
1672	The Khapash Pass. A Mughal army is destroyed in a defile by the Afridis; Aurangzeb comes to Hasan Abdal in the Punjab for eighteen months and quiets the frontier with roads, forts and subsidies. Won by the tribes.
Nov 1675	Guru Tegh Bahadur is executed at Chandni Chowk, Delhi , after taking up the cause of the Kashmiri Pandits. His son, aged nine, succeeds him. Won by Aurangzeb.
Sept 1688	Bhangani. A coalition of hill rajas is defeated; Pathan mercenaries desert the Guru and Pir Buddhu Shah fights for him and loses two sons. Won by Guru Gobind Rai — who wrote the account himself.
1691	Nadaun. The Guru fights a Mughal tribute force alongside the same hill rajas who attacked him three years earlier. Won by the allies — who then settled with the empire.
Vaisakhi 1699	The Khalsa is founded at Anandpur. The Panj Pyare, the initiation, one name for everybody, the five articles — and the Guru takes the rite from the five he has just created.
1700–1704	The sieges of Anandpur. The hill rajas fail, call in imperial troops, and blockade the town until it starves. Safe passage is guaranteed on oath. Won by the besiegers — and the guarantee is broken on the road.
Dec 1704	The Sarsa in flood at night. The family is separated in the dark and never reassembled.

Dec 1704	Chamkaur. Forty Sikhs in a mud compound; Ajit Singh and Jujhar Singh die; and the surviving Sikhs, acting as the Five, order the Guru to leave — and he obeys. Won by the imperial force, which did not get what it came for.
Dec 1704	Sirhind. Zorawar Singh and Fateh Singh, about nine and six, are put to death for refusing to convert. Mata Gujri dies at the same time.
Dec 1705	Khidrana. The forty who had renounced the Guru return, rallied by Mai Bhago , and die holding off the pursuit. The place becomes Muktsar . Won by the forty.
1705–06	The Zafarnama — the Guru’s letter in Persian verse to Aurangzeb, accusing him of a broken oath and asserting that he has lost.
1707–1708	Aurangzeb dies in the Deccan. Guru Gobind Singh is assassinated at Nanded in October 1708, having sent Banda Singh Bahadur north and vested the Guruship in the book. <i>Part Ten begins here.</i>

Five patterns to carry into Part Ten

1. **The institution that outlives the man — finally.** Nine parts of this book have watched states collapse when one person died: the Nandas, Menander’s kingdom, Harsha’s empire, Yashodharman’s alliance, Jasrat’s Punjab, Hemu’s army. Five commanders lost battles they were winning because they personally went down. **At Anandpur in 1699 the problem was deliberately solved, at Chamkaur in 1704 the solution was used, and at Nanded in 1708 it was made permanent.** Part Ten is the first part of this book where the leadership can be killed without the movement ending — and it is tested immediately.
2. **Killing the man leaves the machinery standing.** Jahangir executed a Guru and got an eleven-year-old with two swords. Aurangzeb executed a Guru and got a nine-year-old who founded the Khalsa. A provincial officer killed two children at Sirhind and got an army at his gates in six years. **This book has watched empires make this error since Part Three; here it is made three times in a century by people who should have learned.**
3. **The hills preserve and the hills imprison.** Kiratpur, Paonta, Anandpur, Bhangani, Nadaun — everything in this part happens in the Siwaliks, for the reasons Part Eight set out. You cannot be finished there and you cannot win from there, and Anandpur in 1704 is what the trade eventually costs.
4. **Nothing sorts cleanly by religion, and the people involved knew it.** Hindu rajas besieged the Guru and fought beside him. A Muslim pir lost two sons for him and Muslim mercenaries deserted him. Muslim horse traders hid him from a Muslim emperor’s officers. A Guru died for the Hindu right to a sacred thread. **The wars in this part divide by land, tribute, power and fear — and when they divide by faith it is usually because someone in authority found it useful.**
5. **And the record is now ours.** The *Bachittar Natak* and the *Zafarnama* are first-person Punjabi accounts of Punjabi wars, written by the man who fought them. **For the first time in nine parts, the losing side’s version survives in full — and from here to the end of this book, it never stops.**

COMING NEXT — PART TEN

Banda Singh Bahadur and the Years of Persecution, 1708–1748. A follower sent north from Nanded with a letter of authority raises an army in the Malwa within a year. **Samana in 1709; Sirhind in May 1710**, where Wazir Khan is killed and the town destroyed; the first Sikh administration, its own coinage struck in the Gurus' name, and a land settlement that abolishes the landlords. Then the empire's full weight: Lohgarh, the retreat to the hills, the long siege of **Gurdas Nangal** in 1715, and the executions at Delhi in 1716. What follows is thirty years in which the community is hunted through the Punjab with a price on every head, survives in the forests and the deserts and across the Sutlej — and comes out of it organised into fighting bands. And at the end, in 1739, **Nadir Shah** comes down the road from Kabul, and the Mughal Punjab ends for good.

Words Used in This Part

Miri and Piri

Temporal and spiritual authority. The two swords taken up by Guru Hargobind in 1606, and the doctrine that the two cannot be separated.

Akal Takht

“Throne of the Timeless One.” The raised building facing the Harmandir Sahib at Amritsar, from which decisions binding on the community are taken.

Lohgarh

“Iron fort.” The fortification built at Amritsar under Guru Hargobind; the name is used again later for Banda Singh Bahadur’s stronghold.

Bandi Chhor Divas

“The day of the release of prisoners” — commemorating Guru Hargobind’s release from Gwalior, and coinciding with Diwali.

Bachittar Natak

A composition attributed to Guru Gobind Singh containing a first-person account of his early life and battles, including Bhangani and Nadaun. Near-contemporary and unusually valuable.

Zafarnama

“Epistle of Victory.” The Guru’s letter in Persian verse to Aurangzeb, written after Chamkaur, accusing him of breaking an oath sworn on the Quran.

Khalsa

The order founded at Anandpur on Vaisakhi 1699 — initiated, bound by a common code, taking the names Singh and Kaur, and open to anyone regardless of caste.

Panj Pyare

“The Five Beloved” — the five who came forward at Anandpur in 1699. Also the standing institution of five initiated Sikhs acting collectively, whose decision can bind even the Guru.

Amrit

The initiation rite of the Khalsa, prepared with water and sugar and stirred with a double-edged blade.

Faujdar

A Mughal district military commander. Wazir Khan, the faujdar of Sirhind, is the official responsible for the events of December 1704.

Garhi

A small mud-walled fortified compound of the ordinary Punjabi kind. The one at Chamkaur was not a fortress.

Bedava

The written renunciation signed by the forty who left Anandpur during the siege — and torn up by the Guru after Khidrana.

Chali Mukte

“The forty liberated” — the men who returned and died at Khidrana, which was renamed Muktsar, the pool of liberation.

Sahibzade

The term used for Guru Gobind Singh's four sons, all of whom died in December 1704.

Anandpur

Founded as Chak Nanaki in 1665 by Guru Tegh Bahadur in the Siwalik foothills. The centre of everything in the second half of this part.

Gurbilas

A genre of later Sikh narrative literature about the lives of the Gurus. Devotional in purpose, and the source of most of the detail about the battles of Guru Hargobind.

Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri

Jahangir's own memoir, in which he records and explains his order for the execution of Guru Arjan.

Sirr-i-Akbar

"The Greatest Secret" — Dara Shukoh's Persian translation of the Upanishads, cited against him at his trial for apostasy.

Sources used for this part

- Jahangir, *Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri*, in Rogers and Beveridge's translation — for the execution of Guru Arjan in the emperor's own words
- The letter of the Jesuit **Jerome Xavier** from Lahore, 1606 — independent contemporary corroboration
- The *Bachittar Natak* and the *Zafarnama*, attributed to Guru Gobind Singh — first-person accounts from the Punjab
- The *Gurbilas* literature and later Sikh narrative sources for the battles of Guru Hargobind and the events of 1704–05, treated as devotional tradition and labelled as such
- Mughal court histories of Shah Jahan's reign for Balkh, Badakhshan and Kandahar
- **François Bernier**, *Travels in the Mogul Empire*, for the war of succession and the fate of Dara Shukoh
- Mughal records of the north-west frontier campaigns of 1667–1675
- The buildings at Amritsar and Anandpur, and the gurdwaras marking the sites in Delhi, Sirhind, Chamkaur and Muktsar
- Standard scholarly histories of the later Mughal empire and of the Sikh community in the seventeenth century

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: the relative weight of the political and religious motives in the execution of Guru Arjan; the dating of the Gwalior imprisonment, which the sources place anywhere across a decade; the dates and details of Guru Hargobind's four battles, which rest on later Sikh sources and are barely mentioned in Mughal records; the specific reasons for the execution of Guru Tegh Bahadur, where Mughal record is nearly silent; whether Aurangzeb personally authorised the safe-conduct broken at Anandpur or whether it was given by commanders in the field; and every troop figure in the part.

On method, three things should be said plainly.

First, **this part applies the same test to Sikh sources that earlier parts applied to Persian, Greek and Sanskrit ones.** The *Bachittar Natak* and the *Zafarnama* are near-contemporary and are treated as strong evidence; the *Gurbilas* literature is later and devotional and is treated as tradition. That is not scepticism about the community's memory. It is the same standard used on Kalhana in Part Four, the *Prithviraj Raso* in Part Six and the *Malfuzat-i Timuri* in Part Seven.

Second, **the Mughal side is not treated as one thing.** Akbar left this community alone; Jahangir executed one Guru and later travelled with his successor; Shah Jahan's officers fought four small battles and then let the matter drop for a decade; Aurangzeb's policy was harder again, and much of what was done in the Punjab in 1704 was done by provincial officers while the emperor was two thousand kilometres away. Four emperors, four postures.

Third, **this part has deliberately not described the manner of the deaths at Lahore in 1606 or at Sirhind in 1704.** Both are recorded in the tradition, both are commemorated, and neither requires elaboration here. The historical facts are stated. Anything beyond that would be for effect, and these particular events do not need any.